SHEER DANCE

A monthly publication to engage unity. Learn. Discuss. Contribute. Enjoy.

1 JUN 2019

SHEERDANCE.COM



Open Smooth Dancers enjoy competing at National Collegiate DanceSport Championships 2018. Photo by National Collegiate DanceSport Champsionships Photography Team.

In This Issue

[Get Dancing]

Upcoming Competitions 3
Twin Cities Dance Events 4
Twin Cities Dance Contacts 5

[From the Community]

Dance to the Music 10
Balancing Life and Dance 11

[Special Features]

Westlake Legislation Signed into Law! 12
The USA Dance Tea Dance 14
USA Dance Nationals 16

[Recurring Columns]

Touching People 18
Volunteer Report: Ravi Narayan 21
Follow the Leader 24
On the Radio 27
Is Dance a Relatable Art Form? 29
Results from Around the Country 32



Luke Newberg and Ali Crampton. Photo by Dance Fest Photography Team.

Brought to You By

U Partner Dance, Inc. and:

Advertisers

American Style Congress, Cinema Ballroom, Dance Fest, Grand Jete, Julia Leigh, Minnesota Ballroom and Latin Dance Camp, Minnesota Ballroom Blast, National Collegiate DanceSport Chaptionships, Rapit Printing, Sheer Dance, Stardust Dance Productions, StudioJeff, Twin Cities Open

Photographers

Dance Fest Photography Team, National Collegiate DanceSport Championships Photography Team, Ravi Narayan, State Capitol Staff

Writers

Kaylee Anderson, Miller Balley, Samuel Jawer, Katie from The Girl with the Tree Tattoo, Theresa Kimler, Jake Moe, Kai Petersen, Emily Pofahl, Jonathan Wolfgram

Sections

Discussion

This is a forum where people are invited to express their true feelings about issues in the dance community (while still adhering to our submission guidelines) and propose solutions to the problems we often face. Statements made in the Discussion section do not necessarily reflect the views of *Sheer Dance*, even when written by one of our volunteer staff.

From the Community

Unlike the other sections, there is no cohesive theme to From the Community; it is a catch-all for the unique gems that are submitted by people like you. Here you'll find contributions like event recaps, interviews, tales from a far-off competition, and photos from a local dance event.

Recurring Columns

We have a handful of generous writers who contribute regularly. Each explores a unique, overarching theme of their choice. Each month, in a volunteer report, one of our volunteers fills you in on what they've been doing to make the dance community a better place.

Special Features

Some issues focus on a particular event or theme, and all content relevant to that theme belongs to the Special Features section. E

Upcoming Competitions

Events labeled NQE are qualifying events for the USA Dance National DanceSport Championships.

Gumbo Dancesport Championships - NQE ..... **June 28 - 30**
New Orleans, LA; louisianadancesport.org

Twin Cities Open ..... **July 18 - 21**
Minneapolis, MN; twincitiesopen.com

OKC Dreamcatcher Dancesport Championships - NQE ..... **July 26 - 28**
Oklahoma City, OK; dreamcatcherdancesport.com

Carolina Fall Classic DanceSport Championships ..... **October 4 - 6**
Charlotte, NC; carolinafallclassic.com

MN Ballroom Blast ..... **October 27**
Minneapolis, MN; mnballroomblast.com

Chicago DanceSport Challenge - NQE ..... **October 25 - 27**
Chicago, IL; chicagodancesportchallenge.org

California State DanceSport Championships - NQE ..... **November 16**
usadance-norcal.org

Southeastern DanceSport Championships - NQE ..... **January 31 - February 2**
Dunwoody, GA; dancesportgames.com

Royal Palm DanceSport Championships - NQE ..... **February 28 - 29**
Fort Lauderdale, FL; royalpalmdancesport.org E

Dance to the Music

BY SAMUEL JAWER

Early this semester, I went to dinner with some soon-to-be friends after a Tuesday ballroom practice. After we had finished dinner and were walking back to the dorms, one of the more experienced members of the group asked me a question: "If you had to choose between dancing with a partner and dancing to music for the rest of your career, which would you choose?"



Sydney Kuhan and Samuel Jawer. Photo by Dance Fest Photography Team.

Honestly, I can't remember what my answer was then, but the question has stuck with me as I've continued to dance this semester, and it's one I have continued to ponder. Each is a fundamental part of the essence of ballroom dancing as an activity, and it would truly be a loss to have one without the other. I realized that while I had been forced to learn how to communicate and work with each partner, I had yet to learn how to truly work with and implement the music in my dancing. Of course, I had been shown how to count it and stay on time, but beyond that I found I was at something of a loss as to what music truly meant to my dancing.

Perhaps this is one of the reasons I decided to try my hand at being the music coordinator for the University of Minnesota Ballroom Dance Club this upcoming year: I wanted to learn what it means to actually dance to the music, rather than dance to a beat. I wanted to learn to make the music another partner of sorts, and be able to express myself in that partnership in the same way I express myself to each of my human partners. To do that, I knew I would need to learn each part of music: the pacing and beat, of course, but also the energy, emotion, and elegance that each can bring to a dance.

I'm still young in my dancing career, and I have a long way to go as I'm sure any of my partners can attest to. It will be a long time before I can truly say that music is my partner, but I think that if I ever make it there, it will have been worth every second.



Kelela Puranen and Jake Moe. Photo by Dance Fest Photography Team.

Balancing Life and Dance

BY JAKE MOE

When I first started ballroom dancing in September of last year, I found it to be a great way to take my mind off of the other things I had going on and as a healthy little break in my day. As I became more seriously involved, I noticed finding a balance between dancing and everything else was sometimes hard to do. With so much to learn about something I truly enjoyed doing, it was hard to not dance as much as I could, especially when I had competitions coming up shortly ahead and what felt like not enough time in the day. I found myself having to choose between preparing for competitions or studying for midterms and writing essays, but quickly learned how to deal with these conflicts. To help balance your life with ballroom, you want to be consistent and organized, communicate well with your partner, and set limits for yourself to ensure you are still accomplishing all you need to do.

Once I started practicing with my partners one on one, it was never on a consistent schedule and often conflicted with other events or deadlines. This was difficult to work with as I never truly knew when it was and wasn't time to dance, and the amount of time I committed to dance each week varied between just twice a week and every day of the week. That, along with varying amounts of coursework, meetings, class, and exams, made my schedule always all over the place. To help keep my time more balanced and organized, I started having regularly-scheduled practices each week with my partners, and left some openings where if there was enough time to dance we could, but if not it was no big deal. This helped me to budget my time throughout the week while still practicing as much as I could.

Having a consistent and reliable schedule helps a lot, but sometimes things still come up and you need to reprioritize your schedule and free time. It can be a bit of a hassle, but won't be a huge problem as long as you effectively communicate with your partners. It's important to let them know what you have going on, but as long as they are aware of these issues it gives you time to plan and reschedule. Cancelling a practice is never fun, but it happens, and it's much easier to cancel it in advance instead of getting overwhelmed and doing so last-minute. Having good communication with your partner and an understanding of what they have going on makes you easier to work with, and will make scheduling easier and dancing more fun.

At the end of the day, dance is just a hobby for (most) of us and shouldn't be the highest priority in your life. Sometimes you need to set limits for yourself and put other things in your life first. They might not be as fun or exciting, but the sooner it's out of the way the sooner you can get back to dancing. Even if you have a big event coming up soon and don't feel quite ready for it, it's important you limit your stress from other factors first before you focus as much as you can on your dancing. Once everything is out of the way, it's much easier to have meaningful and helpful practices.

Westlake Legislation Signed into Law!

BY THERESA KIMLER

The senseless and tragic loss of Nic Westlake left his family and friends looking for answers as to how losses like this could occur and why light rail operators are able, with gross negligence, to kill people and return to work three days later without consequence. They found that a portion of the problem was badly written legislation.

Tireless family efforts and efforts of Neli Petkova, Nels Petersen, and Ember Reichgott Junge, along with kind State Legislators Carla Nelson and Cheryl Youakim, passed legislation that started some of the needed legal repairs. Passing legislation is a very difficult and challenging thing to do these days. The new law creates accountability and visibility for light rail operators with the hope they will drive more responsibly and conscientiously, making the light rail system more safe.

The passage of the legislation represents a good and remarkable change made in Nic's name. Though very grateful for this result, family and friends want more. Any one of more than 5 simple, inexpensive, easily implemented safety upgrades to the light rail would have prevented Nic's death and the severe injuries caused to Neli Petkova. Normal, usual, and prudent business practice would call for instant implementation of these changes. The Metro Transit operates differently. Protected by liability caps, they refuse practical change and will apparently have to be forced to reason by further legislative action. With a level of determination that Nic would often exhibit, his family and friends will aggressively pursue further change.

Though not like dance, Nic loved the light rail and believed in it. The hope is that among the many gifts Nic bestowed upon us, making the light rail a safer and more publicly responsive part of our community will be another. E



MN Governor Tim Walz, Peter Westlake, MN Legislators Carla Nelson and Cheryl Youakim, and MN Lieutenant Governor Peggy Flanagan. Photo by State Capitol Staff.

AMERICAN STYLE
CONGRESS

Sunday, July 21st * 9 am

Hyatt Regency Minneapolis

2019 Faculty Includes (subject to change) …

SLAWEK SOCHACKI
World Professional Smooth Champion

ELENA GRINENKO
World Professional Rhythm Champion

EDWARD SIMON
World Professional Smooth Champion

DAN & NICOLE RUTHERFORD
World Professional Rhythm Finalists

& more TBA

Hosted by the
Twin Cities Open Ballroom Championships
Scott & Amy Anderson
TCO.dancesport@gmail.com
612-816-2740

The USA Dance Tea Dance

BY MILLER BALLEY

I AM SO GRATEFUL THAT I HAD THE opportunity to perform at the USA Dance Tea Dance at the end of April. It was different from any other event that I have been a part of so far in the world of ballroom dance. Before the National Collegiate DanceSport Championships, my partner and I, along with another couple on our team, were asked if performing at the Tea Dance would be something that we would be interested in doing. We agreed, as we both love any opportunity to dance for an audience. Usually when we dance, we are competing. This time however, we would just be performing. I used to perform all the time when I was younger because I was very involved in ballet, but this was the first time that I would be performing in ballroom and not receiving marks or critiques from judges. Even though I always have fun when I am competing, I was excited to have the main focus of my dancing be on enjoying myself and connecting with the audience.

I have never been to a tea dance, so I did not really know what to expect. The morning began with a lovely brunch and we socialized with many of the USA DAnce chapter members in attendance. We discussed how we became involved in ballroom and it was great to see so many people that share such a love for dance. I was excited to see that ballroom was such a big part of many people's lives, decades after they first began to dance. I hope that dance is something that I continue to enjoy for many years, like so many of them. After brunch there was social dancing, and we performed about halfway through it. It took place at the LaFayette Club in Minnetonka, and the ballroom was absolutely beautiful. It overlooked the lake and there was plenty of space for us to all do our Smooth choreography. It was a very fun environment to dance in, with so many people clapping for and complimenting our dancing. I enjoyed interacting with, and performing for, so many people who were happy to be dancing at all stages of life, and I look forward to the many fun opportunities that ballroom dance will bring me.



Daniel Korus and Miller Balley. Photo by Dance Fest Photography Team.



MINNESOTA BALLROOM BLAST

26 OCTOBER 2019

BALLROOM DANCING CRITIQUED
ALL DAY. SOCIAL DANCING AN
MUSIC ALL EVENING.

BEGINNERS WELCOM
(AND PREFERREL

DANCERS

Dance your heart out.
Get critiqued by pros.
Have a blast.

SPECTATORS

See some great dancing.
Show off your moves.
Rock out.

Admission is $5/session.

WHEN

Day Session: 9 AM to 5 PM
- Critiqued dancing

Evening Session: 6 PM to 10 PM
- Performances & social dancing

WHERE

Coffman Great Hall
Coffman Memorial Union
300 Washington Ave SE
Minneapolis MN 55455

Coca-Cola

Student Activities
GRANTS INITIATIVES

facebook.com/ballroomblast

MORE AT MNBALLROOMBLAST.COM

The University of Minnesota is an equal-opportunity educator and employer



Photos by Dance Fest Photography Team



Uzo Wamuo and Brittney Heisserer

USA Dance Nationals

BY KAI PETERSEN

THIS YEAR I WAS FORTUNATE ENOUGH to be able to attend the USA Dance Amateur Nationals for the second time. However, this year was much different than before. The venue, located at Utah Valley University, was much larger than before. Both the dance floor as well as the physical space of the venue at least doubled in size, leaving plenty of room for this event to grow.

One benefit of having such a large dance floor was that two events were able to run at the same time. For example on one floor you would have Bronze Smooth, while on the other was Senior III Smooth. This was very advantageous in keeping on time and overall it felt smoother. However, for Standard they choose to have only one heat run at a time, meaning that I was competing on a floor almost twice as big as I'm used to. As I walked out on to the floor I felt like a goldfish in a pond. Yet even with this large of a floor there was still plenty of floor-crafting to be done. Of course for me, ballroom dance competitions aren't all about the dancing.

I had the privilege of spending the weekend competing with my amazing dance partner, and exploring Utah's beautiful national parks with some of my closest friends. We first went to Bryce canyon which still had snow covering parts of it, creating this stunning contrast between the rich reds and oranges of the canyon and white snow. There we ate lunch at the park and I even got to try the park's famous Elk chili, which reminded me a lot of venison. From there we spent our second day over in Capitol Reef doing day hikes. Here we were able to see a diverse range of attractions, from deep gorges, to walking through narrow passes, to seeing petroglyphs and a natural land bridge.

As an avid fan of hiking, Utah was one of the most awe-inspiring experiences I have ever had. From being surrounded by the Rocky Mountains to hiking through gorges with my friends, I am grateful I was able to attend this year's nationals. Weekends like this remind me of why I started to like dance, and in part why I continue dancing: because of the people. E

U dance fest

dance. competition. fun.

March 7-8, 2020



udancefest.com
facebook.com/udancefest

Touching People

The Remarkable Intimacy of DanceSport

BY JONATHAN WOLFGRAM

Many of us dance with other people several times per week, if not every day. We move, our partners move, and this idea of dancing together has become so natural to us that we think little of it. This idea of touching another person is just a part of the sport that, through countless hours of social dancing or practice, we've been desensitized to. Rather than talk about goals or motivation or practice methods this month, I'd like to step a step back to ponder that concept.

When we dance, we're touching another person. Another human being. With thoughts, feelings, and a conscious perspective of the dance that is totally independent of our own.

That's crazy!

We hold hands with them, we grab their backs and their arms, we brush our thighs together. All of these things are expectations of how we touch other people when we ask them to dance, but things we might not even consider until we're on the third date with someone we met on the street. I'm not insinuating that dancing together is inherently romantic or sexual by any means, but it is intimate.

We don't let strangers touch us in any of these ways; it's not a typical aspect of communication nor is it allowable in regular social interactions. We, as people, are private, personal, and often defensive.

We don't want other humans to come take our hands or to stand too close to us, and even times when there is no breach of consent, we consider it weird, touchy, and abnormal behavior.

But if we open with the line "Would you like to dance?" the intimacy that would be creepy in any other context is cherished. We touch total strangers with an intimacy that we avoid in day-to-day life. Not only do we hold hands and brush thighs, but we commit to these actions and focus on connecting with our partner, giving them private information about how fast our



Isabella Armour and Jonathan Wolfgram. Photos by National Collegiate DanceSport Championships Photography Team.

legs are moving, how much tension is in our shoulders, and other qualities of our current state of being that seem too personal to reveal to the rest of the world.

Why then, are we so comfortable letting other human beings, strangers, nonetheless, touch us in such intimate ways? Because we've opened dancing as an avenue for trust.

We hate when people stand too close to us or brush up against us in the streets because we have no trust whatsoever in the other party. We have no idea who they are or where they come from. Even if we do know them and it's a coworker or a friend, we may not be close enough with them to be comfortable trusting them with this intimacy. When we agree to dance with a person, through many hours of conditioning and association, we establish some form of trust that says "You can hold my hand." That trust encapsulates all of these forms of touching, balancing, moving together, and even forfeiting some control over our own bodies for the betterment of the dance. We trust that they won't knock us over or push into a wall, and even moreso, we trust them enough to be comfortable touching them and letting them touch us.



Isabella Armour and Jonathan Wolfgram

That's magical, and at the same time, it's extremely vulnerable. Sharing that trust with another human being is a special experience and not something to be taken lightly.

I'll close by asking you to think back to when you first started dancing. See if you can remember your very first dances when one second you were on the side of the room and the next, there was another person in your arms. Maybe it was weird. Awkward. Scary. Uncomfortable. Any number of emotions might come to mind to describe the dances you had before you learned to establish this line of trust, or before you were desensitized to how weird this all is. Remember that feeling and how that's the way we naturally behave when we're this touchy with another person this fast. Compare that to how you feel now when you touch your partner, and hopefully, you'll have some appreciation for the magical thing that seems normal now.

So next time you dance, remind yourself that there is a person, a living human being, in your arms. Lead or follow, there is another person with a conscious experience that is trusting you in this moment. To me, that never gets old. E

Minnesota Ballroom & Latin Dance Camp

3 DAYS OF DANCE TRAINING WITH 5 WORLD CLASS DANCERS AND EDUCATORS!



Benji Schwimmer
So You Think You Can Dance, Season 2 Winner and US Open Swing Champion



Toni Redpath
US National and World American Smooth Champion



Michael Mead
US National and World American Smooth Champion



Irina Kudryashova
US National and World Rhythm Champion



Thomas Lewandowski
US National and World Latin Champion

OCTOBER 25-27

MNBALLROOMDANCECAMP.COM

THANK YOU TO OUR SPONSORS!

Ballroom Beach Bash

Heart of America DanceSport Championships

Cinema Ballroom & Latin Dancing

Anchor Paper Co.

Why attend the Minnesota Ballroom Dance Camp?

- Unique opportunity to work with some of the best coaches in the US in one weekend
- Private coaching lessons are available for you and your students
- Convenient central location in the upper midwest

SEE MNBALLROOMDANCECAMP.COM FOR MORE INFORMATION AND TO REGISTER

Volunteer Report: Ravi Narayan

USA Dance National Volunteer of the Year

BY EMILY POFAHL

Within our own social spheres, our own jobs, and our own challenges, we sometimes forget about our community – how much it does for us, and how much we could be doing for it in return. Ravi Narayan of the USA Dance Honolulu chapter brought me to this realization when I sat down with him to discuss receiving the USA Dance National Volunteer of the Year title earlier this week. Unfortunately, I was unable to meet with him in person, as he lives in Hawaii, but something about his enthusiasm made me believe that he truly cares about the work he does, and about his community.

Narayan is heavily involved in the USA Dance Honolulu Chapter, and has been since 2008. As a teacher, competitor, and administrator, he is no stranger to the local and national dance community.

"I started ballroom dance about 19 years ago. My wife saw a sign for classes," he said. "We have been teaching ballroom for about 10 years now, only for kids. We started the K-12 program for the USA Dance Honolulu chapter – mostly for Prita."

For the Narayans, ballroom dance is a family affair. Narayan's daughter Prita started the K-12 program along with her parents when she was young, and still is active in ballroom dance today.

There is only one USA Dance chapter within the state of Hawaii, but the members are nearing the thousands, and the people of Honolulu have a lot of interest, according to Narayan. Narayan's role in the chapter is largely undefined, solely because the amount of work he puts in cannot fit into one title.

"We joined the board in 2008, and then soon after we started the K-12 program, which involves teaching twice a week for three hours," said Narayan. "Typically the USA Dance K-12 Coordinators only coordinate the classes – they don't teach; but in our case we ended up being instructors as well."

Narayan then explained to me how else he is involved in the chapter, and how he was unexpectedly thrown into those roles.

"About a year ago, four out of the nine members of our board retired, including the president and the DJ of many years. So, as a result we had to share a lot of the responsibility, so I became the vice president, and I also became the DJ. We were also losing members, so I started email communications – a newsletter."

Out of all of the volunteer work Narayan does for USA Dance, running the K-12 program is his favorite.

"I mean, if I had someone else to do some of the other things I would be happy just running the program," he laughed.

I asked him what his least favorite part of the volunteer work was, and his long, thoughtful pause almost made me think he couldn't think of one. Narayan loves his work. He did eventually discuss his administrative role.

"Probably just the administration. Keeping up with some of the time sensitive things is difficult. I'd say that's my least favorite because when publicizing a workshop or something like that, you have to stay on top of it, which I am not able to do along with everything else."



Photo provided by Ravi Narayan

Narayan and his wife both have full time jobs in addition to their involvement with the Honolulu Chapter. Narayan also competes each year with his daughter Prita at USA Dance Nationals. Being heavily involved in so many activities and professions can be a balancing act, so I inquired after how he does it.

"It's very difficult," he said with a laugh. "It's almost like going from one to the other, and then training for competitions, with no breaks."

Narayan works for a technology company locally in Honolulu, and also teaches at the university there. It's Narayan's commitment to the Honolulu Chapter and USA Dance, on top of his commitment to everything else he's got going on, that really makes him shine as USA Dance's National Volunteer of the Year.

"The president and secretary nominated me primarily because when we lost several members of the board, there was a lot of uncertainty with the organization. In fact, we thought we would have to close down the chapter. We were not really sure we could continue. We were down to five volunteers, and two out of the five were also already thinking of retiring at that point. Luckily they stayed on, but that's part of why I was nominated. We were able to turn it around in the last year -- we were able to keep the organization going. The perception among the community is that we have been doing a decent job since then. We managed to keep the dances going, and we kept the revenue coming in. I've also been trying to keep more communication with Nationals, because we have competitors and we know some of the folks there -- which has not always happened in the past."

The award was presented to him in his home town at the chapter's anniversary dance, and since last year, the chapter has banded together to find stability. Narayan's next mission, and hope for the future of their chapter, is to interact with and bring in younger students to the ballroom dance community.

You can check out a fun-filled performance by the USA Dance Honolulu Chapter on YouTube by typing in "Flash Mob Vid 2.0" by Brooke Johnson. Narayan organized and taught the flash mob for National Ballroom Dance Week, and the chapter took home the award for Best Video.

From our discussion, I realized that Narayan is a role model for cheerfully giving time and effort back to the communities that do so much for us. There is so much to be gained personally and socially from being active in the community.

"It feels good to give back, and it's a way of connecting with the community in a positive way."



Photos provided by Ravi Narayan




USA DANCE PROUDLY PRESENTS THE
NATIONAL COLLEGIATE
DANCESPORT CHAMPIONSHIPS
RETURNING TO
CHICAGO
MARCH
2020
usadanceNCDC.com
facebook.com/groups/usadanceNCDC
USA DANCE
NCDC



Kaylee is a recent graduate of the University of Minnesota, and was a part of their Ballroom Dance Competition Team for three years. She is thrilled to be an essential part of Sheer Dance's team and to gain experience in the field of copy editing, putting her knack for grammar to good use in her monthly column.

Follow the Leader

Opening our Minds to Dance Diversity

BY KAYLEE ANDERSON

I'VE HEARD IT SAID BY MANY THAT everything in ballroom boils down to emphasizing the inherent contrast between "the two genders." To some, women have an inherent allure that draws in an audience as they dance, and that's why people enjoy watching ballroom dancing. While I agree that that can and does happen, I'm not sure I'm 100% on board.

I can see validity in the traditional "tempting woman" act that permeates a lot of professional dancing. The lady in her tall heels, perfectly tanned skin, and toned body struts across the floor like a sex object, her man drooling at the sight of her booty like a cartoon character who can't quite keep his hands to himself. It's tradition, sure, but I don't find it to be very original—and it certainly doesn't seem to be required.

At a professional event I got to see last summer, one of the most entertaining things I witnessed was a professional lead enjoying himself immensely with his partner. He wasn't worshiping her body like she was a goddess, and she wasn't shaking her butt in his face—the gentleman was acting like he was having an amazing time grooving to the music. He even snatched one of the wine glasses from a nearby woman and took a sip, setting it down with a wink before continuing to Mambo.

Ballroom dance always seems to perpetuate society's ingrained gender binary, not because there are supposedly only two genders, but because a lot of us don't see past the traditional partnership. The female follow is required to be the sexy, tempting prey, and the lead must be the insatiable predator. I've seen plenty of choreography reflecting that dynamic, including pieces that are rehearsed but appear non-consensual—such as a man peeking under a woman's skirt as she turns around, pretending to be shocked.

Another way sexual choreography can make things uncomfortable is when a male-female couple with a huge age gap are dancing together. If I'm dancing with someone who's old enough to be my father, if not my grandpa, I would be extremely uncomfortable if he were to act like he were chasing my skirt or admiring my figure. Likewise, I'm sure my male counterparts don't love being sexualized by follows who are also their parents age. While this is not as much an issue in the professional world, it still emphasizes that not every dance between a lead and a follow needs to be sexualized in order to be entertaining. I've seen plenty of showcase dances over the years that have raised an eyebrow or two!

As much as I love ballroom, it's hard to argue that it's at all progressive, especially when a large population of people who dance it are older and less receptive to change. Even for teachers, using the terms "lead" and "follow" in a class instead of "men" and "ladies" can seem strange or unnecessary. The reality is that if we want more young people to enjoy ballroom dance and carry on the sport, we have to stop with this idea that only women and men dance together, and that all dance chemistry is sexy and heterosexual.

Why do we always seem to laugh and cheer more when men dance together, especially? Is it because under our own self-confining rules, one must act male and one must act female? Is a man who "listens" as the follow now effeminate, and that is what amuses us so much? Is it that the concept of affection between two men is so alien that it can't be taken seriously?

There are many ways to interpret how partners relate to each other besides wanting to "get it on". There's the flirtation and the allure like we've discussed before, but there's also two friends sharing a moment together, strengthening their relationship. I don't see much of a difference between best friends having a "girls night out," dancing in a club together, and them dancing a Salsa or a Tango. They're still dancing together, aren't they? Sure there are rules to their dancing, where their feet go and what beat they're supposed to step on, but they're still experiencing the song together, laughing as they lose their balance or strike a pose at the right time.

Coming from a collegiate amateur background, audiences will often see female-presenting people dancing with other women during competitions, and often those people will win over male/female couples. You can argue that they had better technique, or better posture than the other couples, but in competitions where the difference in execution between the top couples is tight, I don't think the "heterosexual image" the other dancers present is giving them the advantage. If we put more effort into training same-sex couples at higher levels, there's a very real chance they could be competitive, especially if biased judges can look past their prejudices and see the dancers for who they are, not the rule-breakers they appear to be.

Don't believe me? At a recent competition I got to watch Championship-level Standard dancers compete, and in contrast to bronze Standard, it's usually tailsuits and frilly dresses as far as the eye can see. Usually. But this time there was a breath of fresh air—a female same-sex couple, walking onto the floor with their heads held high. The lead was wearing black pants and a black quarter-sleeve shirt, covered in slashes of Swarovski rhinestones. Her sleeves were a little flowy as well, which added a beautiful feminine quality to her outfit. She wasn't in a tailsuit with perfectly slicked-back hair, but she still had the look and air of a lead, and her feminine but quiet outfit didn't outshine her follow's at all.

They held their own brilliantly against the other competitors and landed smack-dab in the middle of the pack. The judges absolutely could have ranked them last if they so chose, but it was obvious that their composure and skill made them a highly competitive team. I couldn't have told you who the other couples on the floor were, because I was so entranced by the energy of the all-lady power couple that I had no reason to look away.

In that same competition, I saw two young gentlemen dancing with one another at the Silver level and was consistently impressed by their skill and how they chose to explore their partnership without the predefined male-female relationship that would be expected of them if they were a heterosexual couple. I wouldn't describe the follow in that partnership as being more feminine, although that in itself



Photo by Dance Fest Photography Team


Come Together
TWIN CITIES
open
ballroom championships
July 18 - 21 2019
Hyatt Regency Minneapolis
www.twincitiesopen.com
TCO.dancesport@gmail.com
World Pro-Am DanceSport Series
dancer's cup tour
NDCA
ESTABLISHED 1948
Sanctioned By
NATIONAL DANCE COUNCIL OF AMERICA, INC.

would be a dynamic I would love to see. They chose to display mutual affection and respect for one another, a softer energy than the fiesty predator men are usually expected to portray. Seeing men in dance be vulnerable and trusting is something I would love to see more of, as it's a way of presenting itself that can still be alluring without being sexual or stereotypical.

I love watching choreography that's playful, that shows how dancers relate to one another without making overly-apparent sexual advances at one another. I love dancing with my friends and having a good time, and I love showing the bond that my partner and I have without making his girlfriend in the audience uncomfortable. Large dance organizations trying to oust same-sex couples from their core set of competitors is regressive and frustrating, and hopefully with time and the influence of forward-thinking dancers, those organizations will realize their errors. I can't wait to see the ballroom community learn to celebrate and encourage its diverse couples, especially with June being pride month. There's no time like the present to make ballroom dance a welcoming community! E



Ziqing Lin and Esther Foo. Photo by Dance Fest Photography Team.

ON THE RADIO

Break out your ballroom moves to these Top 100 songs

Viennese Waltz

Incredible
James TW

West Coast Swing

Earth
Lil Dicky

Samba

I Don't Care
Ed Sheeran, Justin Bieber

Rhythm Rumba

Hundred
Khalid

Hustle

Before I Let Go
Beyoncé



MINNESOTA BALLROOM BLAST

26 OCTOBER 2019

BALLROOM DANCING CRITIQUED
ALL DAY. SOCIAL DANCING AN
MUSIC ALL EVENING.

BEGINNERS WELCOM
(AND PREFERREL

DANCERS

Dance your heart out.
Get critiqued by pros.
Have a blast.

SPECTATORS

See some great dancing.
Show off your moves.
Rock out.

Admission is $5/session.

WHEN

Day Session: 9 AM to 5 PM
- Critiqued dancing

Evening Session: 6 PM to 10 PM
- Performances & social dancing

WHERE

Coffman Great Hall
Coffman Memorial Union
300 Washington Ave SE
Minneapolis MN 55455

Coca-Cola

Student Activities
GRANTS INITIATIVES

facebook.com/ballroomblast

MORE AT MNBALLROOMBLAST.COM

The University of Minnesota is an equal-opportunity educator and employer

Is Dance a Relatable Art Form?

Part 2

BY THE GIRL WITH THE TREE TATTOO

Welcome back, dancers!

Last month, I told you about a podcast I had listened to that really got the gears turning in the brain. I pondered the question, "why isn't dance as relatable as other performance art forms like acting or singing?" I concluded that connection and shared experience were key. It's easier for an audience to connect with actors and singers through a shared experience. Dance has a dualistic experience that happens externally and internally at the same time, and dancers don't need an audience in order to feel fulfilled in their dancing. If a dancer isn't able to bring the internal part of the experience out so the audience can connect to it, the audience won't be able to connect and relate to the dance performance. As the panelists in the podcast episode discussed, this lack of relatability could be a major factor in how publicly successful dancers can be, compared to actors or singers.

So how can we make dance more relatable?

Once again, my Vulcan side wants to take the logical approach. We need to make this performance art more relatable, so let's look at how the others make themselves relatable. I already wrote in Part 1 how audiences get to share in an actor's or singer's experience. That connection is important. I think another important factor is the purpose behind the performance. An actor's purpose for example is ultimately to entertain their audience, whether that's through comedy, horror, drama, etc. They portray a character and bring a story to life, all for the entertainment of the audience. They need that audience to fulfill their purpose.

A dancer's purpose can vary, though one general thing popping into my head is a dancer's purpose is to connect movement to music in a way that's rhythmical and inspires an emotional response. You don't need an audience to do that because even the inspired emotional response can come from the dancer. So I think the first step for dancers to take if we want to make our art more relatable to the audience is include them in our purpose. If a performing dancer is only considering the dance itself and their own experience, the audience will find it harder to connect.

In my competition routines, moments to connect with the audience



Photo by Dance Fest Photography Team

are actually included in the choreography. Whether it's simply facing the audience so there is opportunity for eye contact or a gesture in the arm styling that invites the audience to come along with us, connection with the audience is one of the factors used in designing the routines. The dancing isn't dependent on the connection with the audience however. Moments when Teacher and/or I face the audience are also moments meant for us to face away from each other. The routine is just as good in an empty studio as it is at a competition, but the point is we create space for the audience to connect with us, should they be present.

Storytelling is another important factor. Just like actors take their audiences on a journey through the story they're telling, Teacher and I have built specific stories, or at least characters, around our four Open Smooth routines. So the reason behind a particular move is more than it looks cool or it fits with the timing. That move represents a part of the story we're telling. The audience may not be able to fully understand the story we're telling, but just like when a movie opens in the middle of an action sequence, we give enough to let them know, "something is happening here and you should keep watching to see what happens next."

Being open to the audience sharing in the dance experience and being clear about what story or message that dance is conveying will have a huge impact on the audience's ability to relate and connect to the dancer. I emphasize owning who you are as a dancer, but that doesn't mean you isolate or cut yourself off from others. You can step onto a dance floor or a stage in full ownership of who you are, and also be open and inviting to your audience to join you on the journey you're about to start.

I think there needs to be a purpose beyond the dancer for their movements in order for the audience to relate. Thinking back to that story about the b-boy, I would want to know why he wanted to do a whole series of power moves instead of just one. If it was only because he loved those moves or loved how he felt doing those moves, and there was no additional purpose, message or story, then I would agree that the audience wouldn't understand. They can't relate to the skill or technique it takes to execute those moves, so their connection to the dance won't come from there. It will come from the message or story driving those moves.

At the end of the day, if we're talking about dancers getting paid to dance as much as A-list actors get paid to act (which was part of the original question posed to the panel on the podcast), then they need to make their purpose similar to an actor's and entertain their audience. Certain actors get paid millions of dollars for their work because the collective audience market will pay that much for those actors.

Entertained audiences will ask for more. Confused or uninspired audiences will go home and watch Netflix. That doesn't necessarily mean dumbing or watering down a dance performance, but it does mean including the audience in the creation process.

Gene Kelly did groundbreaking and innovative work in choreographing dances for the camera. He didn't create a dance and then film it. He designed the dance to work with the film equipment and be enhanced by these non-dance tools. In doing so, he was able to create a connection with an audience who wasn't present at the time of performance. The camera represented the audience and he was sure to include them.

"If the camera is to make a contribution at all to dance, this must be the focal point of its contribution; the fluid background, giving each spectator an undistorted and altogether similar view of dancer and background. To accomplish this, the camera is made fluid, moving with the dancer, so that the lens becomes the eye of the spectator, your eye." -Gene Kelly The other possible connection an audience can make is to the dancers themselves. I've been drawn to ballroom dancers at a competition who weren't the best dancers on the floor, but something about the person made me feel connected. That something is always their authenticity. It bothers me when I see an overly rehearsed performance. Even professional ballroom dancers are guilty of putting on two to three facial expressions on repeat throughout their performance. Closed-mouth smile. Open-mouth smile. Closed-mouth smile. Open-mouth smile. Are you enjoying the dance or slowly gasping for air?



When a dancer is truly in the moment, letting their natural expression come through, and is inviting the audience to share in what they're feeling, that creates a connection for me as an audience member. Their smile makes me smile! Their fierce expression makes me feel fierce. I've had complete strangers come up to me at a competition to say they loved watching me dance. They weren't dancers, and still, I was able to connect with them on some level that made them want to keep watching AND seek me out afterwards.

So maybe that b-boy could do his series of power moves if he was also able to communicate with the audience about how much he enjoyed doing those moves. Then, the audience could connect with his joy and sense of fun.

This is starting to get long enough to need a Part 3, so I'll conclude here. If we want people to be able to relate to and connect with our dances, we have to first be open to that connection by being authentic and inviting our audience in. We have to dance for more than just ourselves; we have to dance for them too.

With more and more dance showing up in our movies, tv shows, and even commercials, now is a great time to make these shifts. If Gene Kelly could create a 17-minute ballet sequence in An American in Paris that moviegoers ate up, then I think dancers today can easily attract more audiences to their art form. Maybe we just need the next Gene Kelly to step up and show us E

Stardust Dance PRODUCTIONS

WEEKEND GETAWAYS, LUXURY DANCE CRUISES, DANCE DESTINATIONS

118th Weekend Getaway

Friday June 14th - Sunday June 16th, 2019

VILLA ROMA RESORT

Your new adventure awaits

365 Villa Roma Road
Callicoon, New York 12723

Rates starting at $375 pp

(includes resort fees)

Includes:
Lodging • 7 Meals
Cocktail Party/Open Bar Wine/Champagne Party
Over 50 Hours of Workshops
Entertainment Nightly Dancing in 4 Venues
Top Nite Club Entertainment Each Evening
Special Instructor / DJ - John Lindo
Casual Friday Night Country & Western
Wear Your Favorite Jeans

Appearing on our Stage



3 Piece Swing Band

Caribbean Dance Cruise XVII



February 4th - February 14th, 2020

Costa Luminosa

10 Nights • Departs from Ft. Lauderdale, Florida

Itinerary

Ports: Nassau, Bahamas • Amber Cove, Dominican Republic • Ocho Rios, Jamaica • Grand Cayman Island • Mahogany Bay, Roatan • Cozumel, Mexico

RATES STARTING AT $930 PER PERSON

Future Ballroom Dance Camp Weekends

September 13th - 15th, 2019 • November 22nd - 24th, 2019

Call for a Complete Brochure (800) 537-2797 Outside of the US and Canada (845) 794-4707

EMAIL US: INFO@STARDUSTDANCE.COM • VISIT OUR WEBSITE WWW.STARDUSTDANCE.COM

Stardust Dance Productions, LTD is registered with the State of Florida as a Seller of Travel. FLA Seller of Travel Reference # ST37320